CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Wednesday, November 4, 2026 No. 224 13 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. North Korea fired several missiles from Sondok toward the East Sea, the fourth weapons launch in a week.
2. Seoul High Court upheld former President Yoon Suk Yeol's election law conviction, putting 39.7 billion won in PPP campaign funds at risk.
3. US Democrats captured both the Senate and House in midterm elections, reshaping Korea-related legislation prospects.

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,683.80	1,339.06	$102.10	39%	Oct 30	3.00%
+0.6%	−0.4%	−1.4%	flat Oct 27-29	5 days ago	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

Yonhap, DPRK

North Korea fires several missiles toward East Sea, fourth weapons launch in a week

South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff reported several missiles launched from the Sondok area of South Hamgyong Province toward the East Sea on Wednesday morning, with ROK-US analysis of specifications underway. Japan's Defense Ministry issued no alert, suggesting the weapons may have been shorter-range or non-ballistic types.

The launch follows approximately a dozen short-range ballistic missiles fired from Wonsan on October 29 and comes as **Kim Yo Jong** issued a statement calling US talks possible but not necessary, pairing diplomatic messaging with live fire on US midterm election day.

Yonhap / Korea Times, ROK Politics

Seoul High Court upholds Yoon's suspended prison term in election law case; PPP faces 39.7B won liability

The Seoul High Court confirmed a lower court's sentence of 18 months in prison, suspended for three years, against former President **Yoon Suk Yeol** for making false statements during the March 2022 presidential campaign.

If the ruling is finalized on further appeal, it would nullify his election and require the People Power Party to return *39.7 billion won* in campaign reimbursements under election law. The PPP announced it would fight the ruling at the Supreme Court, while the Democratic Party-led legislature separately advanced the so-called fabricated-prosecution special counsel bill over PPP opposition, with the PPP threatening a filibuster.

NK News / Korea Herald / Reuters, DPRK

Kim inspects Nampho Shipyard, reveals new warship class larger than destroyers under construction

KCNA reported that **Kim Jong Un** inspected the Nampho Shipyard on Sunday and was shown a new warship under construction that he described as having a "huge and imposing appearance, which bears no comparison with the destroyer built last year," per NK News analysis of KCNA.

NK News analysis concluded the new vessel represents a third, larger class of warship, and that work on a third destroyer at the same facility appears to have been abandoned. Kim ordered rapid naval buildup and major infrastructure upgrades at the shipyard.

02 | OVERNIGHT

WSJ, DPRK

WSJ: North Korea on busiest missile-testing spree in years, rebuffs Trump diplomacy

Four weapons events in one week, including Wednesday's Sondok launch.

WSJ, DPRK

WSJ: North Korea eager to rebut rogue-nation image with rare personal Binance denial

Kim Yo Jong's on-the-record denial of the $6.36B Binance heist is unusual in DPRK diplomatic practice.

The Washington Post, DPRK

WaPo: North Korea denies involvement in $6.3B Binance crypto heist

MOFA suspects document leaked through overseas diplomatic mission, not cyberattack.

Dong-A Ilbo, ROK Politics

Police probe presidential aircraft passenger manifest leak; 168 names and passport numbers exposed

MOFA suspects document leaked through overseas diplomatic mission, not cyberattack.

Nikkei, NK-Russia-China

Nikkei: North Korea leans on China and Russia to drive 3% economic growth

NK News separately assesses the growth is unsustainable without structural reform.

South China Morning Post, DPRK

SCMP: North Korea's low-cost drone push exposes South Korea's red tape trap

Seoul's new drone development agency launched November 3 to close the asymmetric gap.

03 | STAT OF THE DAY

39.7B won

PPP campaign reimbursement at risk if Yoon conviction is finalized

The Seoul High Court upheld Yoon's suspended 18-month sentence; a final conviction would legally require the People Power Party to return 39.7 billion won in campaign reimbursements under election law.

Yonhap English, Korea Times, Nov 4 appeals court ruling

04 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

No public appearance today, last seen 5 days ago

No KCNA watch flag. 6 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

Reuters / KCNA via Yonhap, DPRK state media

KCNA confirms cruise missile dispersal warhead test, following cluster warhead test

KCNA said North Korea tested a dispersal warhead for a strategic cruise missile, the second new warhead type announced in days after the October 31 cluster bomb warhead test for tactical ballistic missiles.

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Kim Yo Jong, Deputy Director, WPK Propaganda and Agitation Department

Issued KCNA statement rejecting Binance attribution as 'hostile policy,' saying US talks are possible but not necessary for DPRK national interests.

Kim Song Nam, Director, WPK International Department; Secretary, WPK Central Committee

Arrived in Beijing Tuesday on official visit at CCP Central Committee invitation, 10 days after accompanying Kim Jong Un to Dandong.

> **Bottom line:** State media led with Kim's Nampho Shipyard inspection and Kim Yo Jong's dual-track message pairing conditional dialogue with the same day's missile launches, while KCNA also confirmed a cruise missile dispersal warhead test announced by Yonhap on Nov 3.

05 | ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Wednesday, November 4, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Deputy FM Chung Eui-hae

Korea-Switzerland bilateral consultations held in Seoul following Swiss FM's Pyongyang visit

Deputy Foreign Minister Chung Eui-hae held the seventh round of bilateral policy consultations with Swiss Assistant State Secretary Markus Leitner on November 4, reviewing Swiss FM Cassis's October 29-30 Pyongyang visit (where Cassis met FM Choe Son Hui) and discussing Korean Peninsula issues. Seoul called for Switzerland's continued contributions through its Neutral Nations Supervisory Commission role.

Source Korea Times

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Deputy FM Kim Jin-a

APEC Ministerial Meeting attended via video; Korea advances AI cooperation agenda

Deputy Foreign Minister Kim Jin-a participated by video in the 37th APEC Foreign and Trade Ministers' Joint Meeting hosted by China (also via video), co-chaired by Wang Yi and Wang Wentao, discussing open innovation and regional economic integration ahead of the APEC summit. Kim highlighted the APEC AI Initiative led by Korea during its 2025 chair year and proposed AI and technology growth potential as a core agenda for the 2027 OECD Ministerial Council.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

MOFA / Ambassador Baek Tae-ung

OECD 30th anniversary seminar held in Seoul; real GDP tripled since 1996 accession

MOFA held a seminar titled 'OECD 30 Years Together and a New Future' in Seoul on November 4, with Prime Minister Han Seong-sook and OECD Secretary-General Mathias Cormann attending via video and approximately 200 officials, academics, and industry representatives present. Ambassador Baek Tae-ung said Korea has grown from an economy that learned international standards to a major member that shapes global policy agendas.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

MOFA / Regional mission chiefs

2026 Mekong region heads of mission conference held at Vietnam Embassy

Mission chiefs from Vietnam, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos, and Myanmar convened at the South Korean Embassy in Hanoi on November 4, reviewing US-China strategic competition dynamics, the Myanmar situation, the Thailand-Cambodia dispute, and Korean economic diplomacy strategies in mainland Southeast Asia. The conference marked the 15th anniversary of Korea-Mekong cooperation.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

PRESIDENTIAL OFFICE

President Lee Jae-myung

President visits Jangwi public redevelopment site, pledges accelerated housing supply and incentives

President Lee visited the Jangwi District 9 public redevelopment project in Seoul's Seongbuk-gu and held a roundtable with project stakeholders, calling the standard 20-30 year redevelopment timeline excessive and stating that public redevelopment will be incentivized with higher floor-area ratios and streamlined approvals. Lee called metropolitan housing price stabilization the most important policy priority.

Newsis

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

Fabricated-prosecution special counsel bill passed judiciary subcommittee; plenary session standoff with PPP filibuster threat

Judiciary Committee

The Democratic Party-led judiciary committee subcommittee passed the fabricated-prosecution special counsel bill, with the DP announcing plenary introduction. The PPP announced it would mount a filibuster against all legislation in response, and bipartisan plenary negotiations collapsed.

Ruling and opposition parties clash over proposed Future Response Fund creation

Budget and Accounts Committee

The budget committee debated a government proposal to create a new Future Response Fund, with the Democratic Party calling it a fiscal safety net and the PPP dismissing it as an election-campaign slush fund.

06 | US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts
Section 232

15%
Reduced

Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50 percent and autos at 15 percent, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff in force. Section 301 investigations, launched March 11 against 16 trading partners including South Korea, are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B US energy purchases; no official drawdown figure reported to date.

07 | NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Yonhap, China-Korea

Korea-China trade ministers meet in Shanghai, agree to accelerate FTA services and investment talks

South Korea's trade and industry minister held bilateral commerce minister talks with China's counterpart in Shanghai, agreeing to expedite the stalled Korea-China Free Trade Agreement follow-on negotiations covering services and investment, alongside discussions on expanding economic cooperation.

Foreign Ministry, Japan-Korea, Primary

Korea-Poland 7th joint economic committee agrees on defense, battery, and infrastructure cooperation expansion

Deputy Minister for Economic Affairs **Park Jong-han** and Poland's deputy minister of economic development and technology met in Warsaw Tuesday, reviewing implementation of April summit agreements and discussing expansion of K2 tank, K9 howitzer, and Chunmoo rocket launcher cooperation into local production and technology transfer, alongside battery supply chains and infrastructure projects.

08 | KOREA AND THE WORLD

Foreign Ministry, Africa, Diplomacy, Primary

Korea, African Union hold 7th policy consultation on trade, health, and cooperation fund in Addis Ababa

MOFA held the seventh Korea-African Union Policy Consultation in Addis Ababa on November 3, discussing operation of the Korea-Africa cooperation fund and expanding cooperation in trade, investment, health, agriculture, climate, and peace and security, with both sides affirming the AU's role as a channel for deeper Korea-Africa partnership.

09 | BUSINESS & ECONOMY

Korea Times

Imported vehicle sales jump 29.3% in October on strong EV demand; Tesla doubles year-on-year

New registrations of imported vehicles rose to *31,117 units* in October from 24,064 a year earlier, with Tesla Model Y Premium and Model 3 taking the top two spots among imported cars, per Korea Automobile Importers & Distributors Association data. Tesla's Korean sales more than doubled year-on-year to 9,165 units, though fell 25.9 percent month-on-month due to supply shortages.

Tesla

Korea Times

DaouKiwoom-CJ consortium to acquire JoongAng Ilbo for 520B won in debt-workout resolution

A consortium of Daou Technology, CJ, Shinsegae and Saramin will sign a *520 billion won* new share acquisition agreement Thursday, making the group JoongAng Ilbo's largest shareholder and resolving the media group's debt workout program that began in July after parent JoongAng Group's liquidity crisis.

JoongAng Ilbo | CJ | Shinsegae

Yonhap

Chey Tae-won named chair of SK Hynix US AI investment vehicle HYAICO Corporation

SK Hynix named its new US artificial intelligence investment entity **HYAICO Corporation**, with SK Group chairman **Chey Tae-won** taking the board chair role, deepening the group's commitment to US AI infrastructure following the San Francisco AI Summit Vera Rubin and HBM4 partnerships announced in July 2026.

SK Hynix | SK Group

MTN Money Today

FSC settles Hong Kong ELS sanctions after three years, cutting final penalty from 4 trillion to 360B won

The Financial Services Commission concluded a three-year enforcement action on Hong Kong equity-linked securities sales by Korean banks, reducing the initially computed penalty from *4 trillion won* to approximately 360 billion won, roughly 10 percent of the original calculation, in the final sanction decision.

10 | UPCOMING

NOV 5

JoongAng Ilbo acquisition contract signing

The DaouKiwoom-CJ consortium signs the 520 billion won new share acquisition agreement with JoongAng Ilbo on Thursday, resolving the media group's debt workout.

NOV 6

Samsung Biologics second strike; 400 workers

Samsung Biologics workers launch a second strike on November 6 involving approximately 400 employees, following a first round of industrial action.

NOV 9

Democratic Party holds field supreme council meeting in Gumi

The Democratic Party holds an out-of-Seoul field supreme council meeting in Gumi, North Gyeongsang Province, as part of an outreach drive into traditional PPP strongholds.

NOV 17

JoongAng Ilbo bondholders meeting

JoongAng Ilbo's scheduled bondholders' meeting on November 17 will vote on repayment of corporate bonds from the consortium's investment proceeds.

NOV 18

KFTC full commission meeting on Naver-Dunamu merger

The Korea Fair Trade Commission full commission meets November 18 on the proposed merger between Naver and Dunamu (operator of Korea's largest crypto exchange Upbit), with a decision possible in November.

11 | ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

Minister of Trade/Industry (MOTIR) (@MinisterofMOTIR), November 4

"AI Factory is a core sector. After supporting 245 companies to convert to AI Factories and developing 541 AI models, an analysis of 38 outstanding cases shows productivity improved by an average of 30.1 percent and defect rates fell 15.5 percent."

The minister held an AI Factory strategy meeting today reviewing one year of outcomes, with stated intent to scale the program from individual pilot cases to sector-wide deployment across Korean manufacturing. **View on X**

Unification Minister Chung Dong-young (@coreacdy), November 4

"Wild boars crossing the military demarcation line carry African swine fever. We are preparing to advance inter-Korean joint quarantine cooperation step by step to manage livestock disease including swine fever, foot-and-mouth disease, and avian influenza."

Chung cited a 2019 precedent where North Korea first reported 770,000 pig deaths from swine fever to the World Organisation for Animal Health, and referenced an inter-Korean agricultural and fisheries cooperation agreement from the Roh Moo-hyun era as the legal foundation for proposed joint quarantine. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

COMMENTARY

Modernizing North Korea's 240 mm MLRS: Precision, Automation, and Extended Range. 38 North reports that North Korea conducted a test firing of an upgraded 240 mm multiple-launch rocket system with new precision, automation, and extended range features. The analysis examines how these upgrades change the threat calculus for South Korean and US forces within range of the system. (Hyosam Lee, 38 North)

[Sejong Policy Studies 2026-07] North Korea and Europe after COVID-19: Explaining Divergent Bilateral Relations. Drawing on 14 interviews with European observers and former North and South Korean officials, Ward finds that North Korea's approach to Sweden, Switzerland, Germany, and the UK reflects significant long-run differences in humanitarian assistance, diplomatic roles, and sanctions posture. The paper concludes that Stockholm and Bern offer potential channels through which Seoul might engage Pyongyang, while Germany and the UK face continued resistance. The finding is directly relevant to today's ROK-Swiss consultations in Seoul following Swiss FM Cassis's October 29-30 Pyongyang visit. (Peter Ward, sejong.org)

The Strategic Implications of the Russia-North Korea Axis. The conference examines the Russia-North Korea relationship through three lenses, theory, North Korea's calculus, and Russia's calculus, to assess whether a tactical alignment is hardening into a lasting strategic alliance. (CSIS Center for Strategic and International Studies)

12 | PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

39%

0 pts vs Oct 13-15
Gallup Korea
October 27-29, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 7 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
35%	30%	28%

13 | THE WIRE

DPRK

NK News

Kim Yo Jong says US talks possible but 'not a necessity,' rejects Binance attribution as hostile policy

Kim Yo Jong said Wednesday via KCNA that Pyongyang is open to US dialogue but does not consider it necessary for national interests, reiterating that the FBI's attribution of the $6.36 billion Binance heist to DPRK cybercriminals reflects Washington's "invariable hostile policy" and demanding the US abandon that policy as a precondition to any engagement.

NK News

North Korean propaganda loudspeakers installed at two inter-Korean border sites; no broadcasts audible

NK News observed propaganda loudspeakers installed on the North Korean side of the border at Odusan Unification Observatory in Paju and Key Observatory in Yeoncheon on Wednesday, with no audible broadcasts detected from the South Korean side despite the visible installations.

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA

NK News

WPK International Department director Kim Song Nam arrives in Beijing 10 days after Kim Jong Un's Dandong visit

Kim Song Nam, director of the Workers' Party of Korea International Department and WPK Central Committee secretary, arrived in Beijing Tuesday on an official visit at the invitation of the Chinese Communist Party Central Committee, KCNA reported Wednesday, 10 days after accompanying Kim Jong Un to Dandong; a Chinese Communist Party Central Party School delegation was simultaneously in Pyongyang.

14 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

New imagery reports, Oct 16, Nov 4

Satellite imagery shows 100-meter vessel grounded outside Chongjin port since mid-October; expert assesses intentional beaching for scrapping

Planet Labs imagery from October 16-19 shows a vessel measuring roughly 100 meters appearing outside the Chongjin port adjacent to the city's old steel mill, with the ship remaining grounded as of November 4. At least three smaller boats and a 120-meter cargo carrier approached the site on October 19 and 28, with no successful salvage apparent. Former UN maritime tracking official Neil Watts assessed that the ship's proximity to the steel mill and absence of adverse weather conditions suggest intentional beaching for dismantling rather than an accidental grounding.

Sinpo South Shipyard

NK News / Planet Labs

ACTIVITY, RISING

Sinpo South Shipyard

As of May 2025: Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine exited drydock after 2+ years of fitting-out but was still not operational. New submarine construction begun in separate bay. NK Pro satellite analysis (Oct 20 2026) separately reports North Korea's Nampho Shipyard missed a deadline earlier in Oct 2026 to launch a 5,000-ton naval destroyer, with hull sections visible at two potential outdoor assembly areas. 38 North analysis published Oct 30 documents public display of a vessel described as a 'Tactical Nuclear Attack' submarine. Kim Jong Un inspected Nampho Shipyard on Nov 2 (reported Nov 4 by KCNA), announcing a new warship under construction larger than the destroyer built last year.

imagery as of 2026-11-04

MONITORING

Yellow Sea NLL

As of September 26, 2025: 140m DPRK merchant vessel Toksong crossed the Northern Limit Line near Baengnyeong Island, advanced 5km south. ROK Navy fired approximately 60 warning shots; vessel retreated after 1 hour. ROK Marine Corps Commandant Gen. Ju Il-suk stated October 20 2026 that North Korea has made 'various changes' to forces facing South Korea's border islands, with Seoul stepping up surveillance along the maritime border. 38 North satellite imagery published October 29 shows North Korea continuing to install new fencing along its border. North Korean propaganda loudspeakers were visible at two border locations on Nov 4 from Odusan Unification Observatory and Key Observatory in Gyeonggi Province, with no audible broadcasts detected from the South Korean side.

imagery as of 2026-11-04

9 other monitored sites: no new reporting since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 224

TOMORROW

JoongAng Ilbo acquisition contract signing

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

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